AI Delegation, Human Judgment, and the Question of Restraint

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My current research examines a problem that is becoming more visible as generative AI becomes embedded in everyday cognitive work: What happens to human judgment when we delegate increasingly complex cognitive activity to AI?

I am not approaching this primarily as a question of whether AI will become autonomous, conscious, or more intelligent than humans. My concern is with the human side of delegation. AI can already summarize, compare, classify, draft, recommend, revise, and help evaluate alternatives. As these capabilities improve, the range of activities that can be delegated continues to grow. But capability alone does not tell us what should be delegated, how far delegation should go, or when an earlier decision to delegate should be reconsidered.

An AI system may perform exactly the task it has been given. Its output may be accurate, and the human may still have final authority. Yet the instruction can begin to work against the larger purpose for which the task was delegated.

A simple example emerged recently in my own work with generative AI. I asked an AI system to prepare a one-page explanation of my research for another scholar. It repeatedly produced reasonable and largely accurate drafts, yet I remained dissatisfied. Eventually it became clear that the one-page instruction itself was forcing compression at exactly the point where the argument needed fuller explanation.

Nothing had technically malfunctioned. The system was following my instruction, and I remained free to reject its output. But successful compliance with the task had begun to work against the purpose that motivated the delegation. This has led me to distinguish task execution from the continuing governance of delegation.

I am developing the concept of Delegated Momentum to examine this problem. I use the term provisionally for the tendency of authorized machine-mediated activity to continue under an instruction or authorization even when changing conditions mean that the human should pause and judge again. This does not require a rogue or autonomous machine. It can arise when the system is working competently. Initial human authorization sets activity in motion, while machine speed, scale, and capacity allow that activity to continue. But authorization at one moment does not necessarily justify continued delegation later.

This shifts my question from simply asking what humans should delegate to AI to asking how humans remain capable of governing what they have already delegated.

Contemporary work on meaningful human control, appropriate reliance, contestability, and human oversight provides important parts of the answer. My interest is particularly in what these arrangements require from the human side. Keeping a human formally in charge is not enough by itself. The human still has to judge whether the AI is being given more authority than its capability warrants, whether following an instruction is still serving the larger purpose, whether assistance is beginning to replace human judgment, and whether the terms of delegation need to be reconsidered.

This is where my interest in the ancient Indic classical philosophical tradition becomes central. Sāṃkhya and Yoga are not modern theories of technology. They are old philosophical traditions concerned with basic questions about cognition, consciousness, human action, disciplined attention, suffering, and liberation. Their ideas developed over a long period in the Indic civilizational world. The surviving classical Sāṃkhya text most important for my work is Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Sāṃkhya Kārikā, generally placed in the middle centuries of the first millennium CE, although its precise dating

remains debated. Patañjali's Yoga Sūtra is also usually placed in the early centuries CE, with its chronology likewise debated.

I am not claiming that these texts anticipated artificial intelligence. I am interested in what they do philosophically. They make careful distinctions among cognition, consciousness, action, and the capacities needed for clearer human judgment. These distinctions give me another way to ask what remains specifically important on the human side when more cognitive work is performed through machines.

Sāṃkhya is especially useful because it does not simply equate cognitive activity with consciousness. It distinguishes prakṛti, the domain of activity and transformation, from puruṣa, consciousness. Within prakṛti, buddhi performs determination or ascertainment. In other words, sophisticated cognitive functioning does not by itself settle the question of a conscious knower.

I do not use this to claim that AI is prakṛti or that a machine can simply be mapped onto Sāṃkhya categories. Rather, the distinction helps me ask a contemporary question without first having to solve the disputed question of machine consciousness: what happens when human intention is carried forward through increasingly sophisticated machine-mediated cognitive activity? AI does not need to possess an independent moral intention for delegated activity to have significant consequences. Human intention can be operationalized through machine speed and scale while responsibility for authorizing and governing that activity remains human.

Yoga takes the inquiry toward the human who must exercise that responsibility. Its treatment of viveka, discriminative awareness, asks us to take seriously the human capacity to distinguish clearly. I use this comparison cautiously. Viveka, and particularly viveka-khyāti, has a much deeper meaning within Yoga's own soteriological setting; I am not translating it simply as AI literacy or fact-checking. My question is whether this classical concern with disciplined discrimination can help us think about distinctions that AI increasingly makes difficult: performance and warrant, capability and authority, assistance and substitution, and successful execution and fulfillment of purpose.

This also brings me to restraint. Restraint does not mean opposition to AI or delegating less by default. It means retaining the human capacity to pause or interrupt delegated activity long enough to ask whether continued delegation is still warranted. The answer may be to continue, change the instruction, narrow or expand the task, pause the process, or take the judgment back.

I therefore see responsible AI delegation as an ongoing process rather than a one-time decision. Giving an AI system a task does not end the human role. As the system continues to work, the human may need to reconsider whether the original instruction still serves the larger purpose. Sometimes that means allowing the work to continue. At other times, it may mean changing the instruction, narrowing the task, pausing the process, or taking the judgment back. In this sense, responsibility continues after the initial act of delegation.

At the institutional level, the problem becomes more complicated. Organizations do not themselves possess viveka. Human beings do. But institutions can create conditions that protect or undermine human discernment through policies, professional norms, workflow design, time pressures, incentives, and decision boundaries.

This is one reason I see an interesting intersection with journalism. Newsrooms involve judgments that cannot easily be reduced to factual accuracy: what deserves attention, which sources warrant confidence, what context is necessary, when evidence is sufficient, what should not yet be published, and when speed should give way to verification. At the same time, journalism faces strong pressures toward speed, automation, efficiency, and increasingly AI-mediated workflows.

The question, then, is not simply whether journalists remain "in the loop." It is whether AI-assisted journalism preserves the conditions under which journalists can continue developing and exercising

the judgment needed to decide where that loop should be drawn, when it should be interrupted, and when the terms of delegation themselves need reconsideration.

This is where I see a possible crossover between my work and research on AI, journalism, innovation, and editorial authority. I approach the problem through communication ethics, comparative ethics, and classical Indic theories of cognition, discernment, and restraint. Journalism provides a concrete professional and institutional setting in which these questions are already becoming practical.

My larger project, *Sattva Intelligence*, develops this inquiry around human alignment and responsible AI delegation. The central concern is not how to make machines morally wise. It is how to preserve and cultivate the human capacities required to govern increasingly powerful machine-mediated activity.

The larger question I am pursuing is: What does meaningful human judgment require when more of the cognitive work surrounding that judgment is delegated to AI?